RATING METHODOLOGY

12 September 2025

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Rating Methodology

Media

This rating methodology replaces the *Media* methodology published on 22 June 2021. We have made editorial changes throughout the methodology to enhance readability, including expanding the "Other considerations" section for enhanced consistency across our corporate sector methodologies. These updates do not change our methodological approach.

Scope

This rating methodology applies to media companies globally, including broadcasters, cable networks, publishers and other media companies that are primarily engaged in the sale of advertising or content but do not have significant other sources of revenue and cash flow.

The determination of a company's primary business is generally based on the preponderance of the company's business risks, which are usually proportionate to the company's revenue, earnings and cash flows.

We also use this methodology to rate outdoor advertisers, which generally rely primarily on advertising revenue. These companies lease advertising space on billboards and other displays to customers. Additionally, we use this methodology to rate a wide variety of companies that are primarily engaged in the print and digital publishing industry, such as publishers of newspapers, magazines, directories, textbooks and databases.

Companies that have significantly or completely transitioned their business to digital platforms, or that were founded as digital-only businesses, fall within the scope of this methodology if they derive most of their revenue or cash flow from the sale of advertising or content.

We rate more diversified media companies using our methodology for business and consumer services, because these companies typically derive significant portions of cash flow from segments not tied to advertising or subscription fees, such as theme parks or movie studios.[1] We rate companies primarily engaged in providing the physical assets to distribute content to consumers using our methodology for telecommunications service providers.

Sector overview

Most companies in the media industry globally purchase content or create content that drives advertising revenue.

For television and radio broadcasters, the quality and reach of original and acquired content, such as news, episodic programming, films, sports and music, all drive advertising revenue. Television broadcasters also generate revenue from retransmission fees paid by distributors, such as cable, satellite and telecommunications companies, which deliver the content to consumers. Like television broadcasters, cable networks also generate advertising and distribution revenue, but they typically control more of the content.

Companies that are primarily engaged in the print and digital publishing industry rely on revenue from advertisers or sell content to customers. For example, newspaper and textbook publishers sell content on digital or print platforms. Some companies, such as commercial printers and check printers, provide print-related services, and other companies provide niche media-related services.

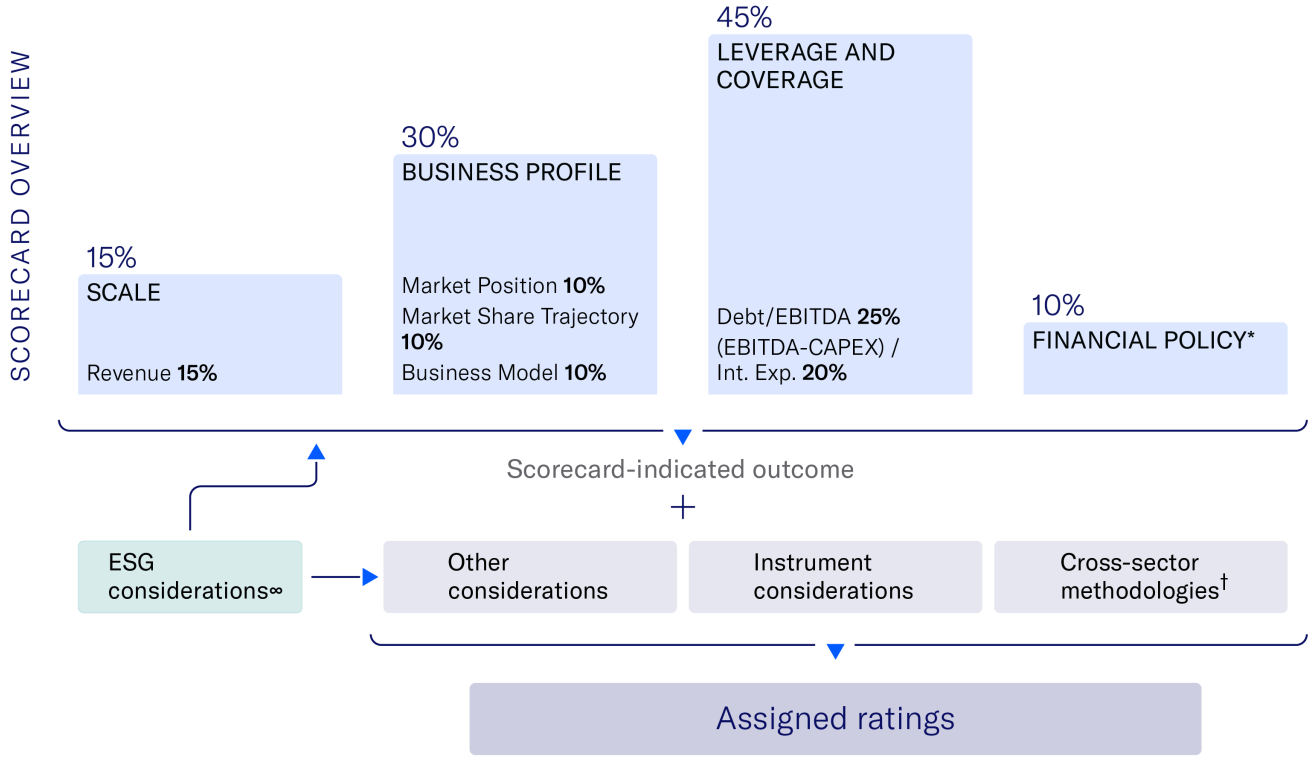
Technological advances and competitive pressures have prompted essentially all media companies to extend the distribution of their products and services to digital platforms, creating shifts in revenue and cost structures. As customers consume media in new ways, including through the rapid growth of streaming formats relative to linear, business models have evolved, and companies have experienced different degrees of success in the transition.

Rating approach

In this methodology, we explain our general approach to assessing credit risks of companies in this sector, including the quantitative and qualitative factors likely to affect rating outcomes.

The following exhibit illustrates our overall rating approach in the analysis of companies in this sector, which includes the use of a scorecard. The scorecard-indicated outcome may not match a company's assigned rating, which is determined by a rating committee. For more information, see the "Other considerations" and "Limitations" sections.

Exhibit 1
Illustration of the media rating approach



* This factor has no subfactors.
∞ Environmental, social and governance (ESG) considerations, including, where available, our opinions of exposure to them as expressed in Issuer Profile Scores (IPSs), may affect scorecard factors and other considerations outside of the scorecard. For more information, see the "Other considerations" section.
† Some of the methodological considerations described in one or more cross-sector methodologies may be relevant to ratings in this sector. A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.
Source: Moody's Ratings

Scorecard

The scorecard in this methodology is a relatively simple reference tool that can be used in most cases to approximate credit profiles of companies in this sector and to explain, in summary form, many of the factors that are generally most important in assigning ratings. The scorecard may not include or address every consideration a rating committee may assess in assigning ratings to companies in this sector.

Exhibit 2

Media scorecard

	SCALE (15%)		BUSINESS PROFILE (30%)		LEVERAGE and COVERAGE (45%)				FINANCIAL POLICY (10%)
	Revenue (USD Billion)[1] (15%)	Market Position (10%)	Market Share Trajectory (10%)	Business Model (10%)	Debt / EBITDA (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[2] (25%)	Debt / EBITDA (Publishers)[2] (25%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[3] (20%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Publishers)[3] (20%)	
Aaa	≥ $40	**Broadcasters:** Effectively all revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 90% of revenues from exceptionally attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 10 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Overwhelmingly dominant market share or brand; and exclusive content with effectively all major media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Strong dominance with minimal competition for content/services that are difficult to replicate; and very high entry barriers generally backed by government protection.	Substantial increase	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Exceptional revenue diversification; revenues are extremely stable or subscription-based; and exceptional potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media. **Publishers: 3+** distinct business segments; exceptional business and geographic revenue diversification; largest market < 25% of revenue; and exceptional potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media.	≤ 0.5x	≤ 0.5x	≥ 15x	≥ 15x	Expected to have extremely conservative financial policies (including risk and liquidity management); very stable metrics; essentially no event risk; and public commitment to very strong credit profile over the long term.

	SCALE (15%)	BUSINESS PROFILE (30%)			LEVERAGE and COVERAGE (45%)				FINANCIAL POLICY (10%)
	Revenue (USD Billion)[1] (15%)	Market Position (10%)	Market Share Trajectory (10%)	Business Model (10%)	Debt / EBITDA (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[2] (25%)	Debt / EBITDA (Publishers)[2] (25%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[3] (20%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Publishers)[3] (20%)	
Aa	$20 - $40	**Broadcasters:** Vast majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 80% of revenues from highly attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 25 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Very dominant market share or brand; and exclusive or premium content with most major media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Strong dominance with some competition for content/services from smaller providers; content is difficult to replicate without investment at a scale beyond most competitors; and high entry barriers generally backed by government protection.	Low-double-digit percentage increase	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Excellent revenue diversification; revenues are predominantly stable or subscription-based; and excellent potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media. **Publishers: 3+** distinct business segments; excellent business and geographic revenue diversification; and excellent potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media.	0.5x - 1x	0.5x - 1x	10x - 15x	12x - 15x	Expected to have very conservative financial policies (including risk and liquidity management); stable metrics; minimal event risk that would cause a rating transition; and public commitment to strong credit profile over the long term.
A	$10 - $20	**Broadcasters:** Majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 70% of revenues from very attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 35 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Leading market share or brand; premium content with majority of revenues generated by media properties in leading positions. **Publishers:** Strong position with some competition for content/services from smaller providers; content can be replicated but requires sizable investment by competitors; entry barriers exist but partially market-based with government oversight.	Single-digit percentage increase	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Very good revenue diversification; majority of revenues are stable or subscription-based; very good potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media. **Publishers: 3+** distinct business segments; very good business and geographic revenue diversification; very good potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media.	1x - 1.5x	1x - 1.5x	7x - 10x	9x - 12x	Expected to have predictable financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that preserve creditor interests. Although modest event risk exists, the effect on leverage is likely to be small and temporary; strong commitment to a solid credit profile.

	SCALE (15%)	BUSINESS PROFILE (30%)			LEVERAGE and COVERAGE (45%)				FINANCIAL POLICY (10%)
	Revenue (USD Billion)[1] (15%)	Market Position (10%)	Market Share Trajectory (10%)	Business Model (10%)	Debt / EBITDA (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[2] (25%)	Debt / EBITDA (Publishers)[2] (25%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[3] (20%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Publishers)[3] (20%)	
Baa	$4 - $10	**Broadcasters:** Majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 50% of revenues from attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 50 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Above-average market share or brand; premium content and majority of revenues generated by media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Largest provider in a field of competitors; content/services can be replicated but requires sizable investment by competitors; entry barriers exist but largely market-based with modest government oversight.	Flat to marginally increasing	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Good revenue diversification; moderate level of revenues are stable or subscription-based; good potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media. **Publishers: 3+** distinct business segments; good business and geographic revenue diversification; good potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media.	1.5x - 2.5x	1.5x - 2x	4x - 7x	6x - 9x	Expected to have financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that balance the interests of creditors and shareholders; some risk that debt-funded acquisitions or shareholder distributions could lead to a weaker credit profile.
Ba	$1.25 - $4	**Broadcasters:** Majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 50% of revenues from fairly attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 75 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Average market share; competitive content and majority of revenues generated by media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Leading provider but competition exists; ongoing investment necessary to sustain brand name/position, but content/services can be differentiated; cost of entry is reasonable for most providers.	Generally flat	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Average revenue diversification; a fairly modest portion of revenues are stable or subscription-based; some potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media. **Publishers: 2+** distinct business segments; average business and geographic revenue diversification; some potential to benefit from emerging business opportunities, including technology or new media.	2.5x - 4.25x	2x - 3x	2.25x - 4x	3x - 6x	Expected to have financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that tend to favor shareholders over creditors; above-average financial risk resulting from shareholder distributions, acquisitions or other significant capital structure changes.

	SCALE (15%)	BUSINESS PROFILE (30%)			LEVERAGE and COVERAGE (45%)				FINANCIAL POLICY (10%)
	Revenue (USD Billion)[1] (15%)	Market Position (10%)	Market Share Trajectory (10%)	Business Model (10%)	Debt / EBITDA (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[2] (25%)	Debt / EBITDA (Publishers)[2] (25%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[3] (20%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Publishers)[3] (20%)	
B	$0.5 - $1.25	**Broadcasters:** Less than majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 40% of revenues from modestly attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 100 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Average market share; less than majority of revenues generated by media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Among leading providers in competitive field or strong niche position; content/services can be differentiated through investment.	Marginally declining to flat	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Below-average revenue diversification; a modest portion of revenues are stable or subscription-based; some risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment. **Publishers: 2+** distinct business segments; below-average business and geographic revenue diversification; some risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment.	4.25x - 6.25x	3x - 5x	1.5x - 2.25x	1.5x - 3x	Expected to have financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that favor shareholders over creditors; high financial risk resulting from shareholder distributions, acquisitions or other significant capital structure changes.
Caa	$0.25 - $0.5	**Broadcasters:** Less than majority of revenue generated from stations with lead rankings, with > 25% of revenues from modestly attractive markets. In the US, this means the top 100 markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Below-average market share; moderate percentage of revenues generated by media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Similar-size competitors exist where content/services can be differentiated; or is a leading or specialized niche participant in industry where products/services have more commodity attributes and large number of competitors exist.	Moderate deterioration	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Modest level of revenue diversification; revenues are largely cyclical or lack stability over cycles; above-average risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment. **Publishers: 2+** distinct business segments; modest level of business and geographic revenue diversification; above-average risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment.	6.25x - 8.75x	5x - 8x	1x - 1.5x	1x - 1.5x	Expected to have financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that create elevated risk of debt restructuring in varied economic environments.

	SCALE (15%)	BUSINESS PROFILE (30%)			LEVERAGE and COVERAGE (45%)				FINANCIAL POLICY (10%)
	Revenue (USD Billion)[1] (15%)	Market Position (10%)	Market Share Trajectory (10%)	Business Model (10%)	Debt / EBITDA (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[2] (25%)	Debt / EBITDA (Publishers)[2] (25%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other)[3] (20%)	(EBITDA - CAPEX) / Interest Expense (Publishers)[3] (20%)	
Ca	< $0.25	**Broadcasters:** Only a modest percentage of stations have lead rankings; revenues are generated predominantly from small markets. **Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Poor market share; modest percentage of revenues generated by media properties in leading market positions. **Publishers:** Smaller participant in an industry with commodity content/services and large number of competitors, many of which have more investment capacity.	Significant deterioration	**Broadcasters and Cable Networks, Outdoor Advertisers and Other:** Lack of revenue diversification; revenues are largely cyclical and lack stability over cycles; high risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment. **Publishers:** Single business segment; lack of business and geographic revenue diversification; high risk or threat from changes in technology and business environment.	> 8.75x	> 8x	< 1x	< 1x	Expected to have financial policies (including risk and liquidity management) that create elevated risk of debt restructuring even in healthy economic environments.

[1] For the linear scoring scale, the Aaa endpoint value is $60 billion. A value of $60 billion or better equates to a numeric score of 0.5. The Ca endpoint value is $0.04 billion. A value of $0.04 billion or worse equates to a numeric score of 20.5. For broadcasters, revenue is calculated on a two-year average basis.
[2] For the linear scoring scale, the Aaa endpoint value is 0x. A value of 0x equates to a numeric score of 0.5. The Ca endpoint value is 15x. A value of 15x or worse equates to a numeric score of 20.5, as does a negative Debt/EBITDA value. For broadcasters, Debt/EBITDA is calculated using two-year average EBITDA.
[3] For the linear scoring scale, the Aaa endpoint value is 40x. A value of 40x or better equates to a numeric score of 0.5. The Ca endpoint value is (1)x. A value of (1)x or worse equates to a numeric score of 20.5. For broadcasters, interest coverage is calculated using two-year average EBITDA minus capital expenditures.
Source: Moody's Ratings

Discussion of the scorecard factors

In this section, we explain why each scorecard factor or subfactor is a meaningful credit indicator, and we discuss our analytical approach to scoring each factor or subfactor. When a factor comprises subfactors, we score at the subfactor level. Some factors do not have subfactors, in which case we score at the factor level.

In assessing quantitative subfactors, we use information that we calculate or estimate from a company's financial statements or regulatory filings, or that we derive from other observations. We may incorporate nonpublic information qualitatively in our assessment.

Our ratings are forward-looking and reflect our expectations for future financial and operating performance. However, historical results are helpful in understanding patterns and trends in a company's performance, as well as for peer comparisons. We typically calculate or estimate financial metrics, unless otherwise indicated, based on an annual or other 12-month period (for broadcasters, we typically use two-year averages for some metrics). However, we may assess the scorecard factors using various periods. For example, we may find it analytically useful to examine both historical and expected future performance for periods of several years or more.

All of the quantitative credit metrics in the scorecard incorporate our standard adjustments to income statement, cash flow statement and balance sheet amounts for items described in our cross-sector methodology on financial statement adjustments for nonfinancial corporations.[2] We may also make nonstandard adjustments that are specific to a particular company.

For a discussion of scorecard mechanics, see the "Scorecard-indicated outcome" section.

Factor: Scale (15% weight)

Why it matters

Scale is an important indicator of the overall strength of a company's business, the size of its market and the company's relevance within an industry and the economy. Scale is also an indicator of a company's importance to its customers and its bargaining strength with suppliers, as well as its ability to invest resources to maintain its competitive position and expand its marketing and geographic reach.

Scale enables a media company to spread costs across a larger base of advertisers, distributors or subscribers, obtain premium rates from advertisers and distributors, and negotiate more favorable terms with content suppliers, talent and other vendors.

How we assess it for the scorecard

We score this factor based on one quantitative subfactor: Revenue.

Revenue

We use total reported revenue in billions of US dollars to measure scale, or to estimate it in the case of forward-looking expectations.

For broadcasters, we typically use a two-year average to smooth the volatility created by the predictable, significant boost in political advertising revenue broadcasters receive during election years. In the US, major elections follow a two-year cycle that strongly affects advertising revenue. In other jurisdictions, advertising revenue may follow different cycles.

Factor: Business Profile (30% weight)

Why it matters

The business profile of a company is important because it greatly influences its ability to generate sustainable earnings and operating cash flow.

Market Position

Market position is a useful indicator of a media company's position relative to its peers and within its target markets. The degree of competition a company faces is important because it directly affects its pricing power, its ability to keep and add customers, and hence the quality and level of its cash flow. A strong market position also allows a media company to hire superior talent and to better negotiate with advertisers and vendors, including content suppliers.

For broadcasters, the percentage of revenue generated from attractive markets is also important because these markets command premium pricing and typically generate a disproportionate share of overall advertising revenue. Advertisers and consumers are often willing to pay a premium in larger markets or markets with other favorable characteristics, such as the ability to reach key demographic groups.

For cable networks, exclusive content and a strong brand provide better negotiating leverage with distributors and advertisers, as well as higher demand from consumers to support expanded distribution channels, such as direct-to-consumer online offerings. Leading outdoor advertising companies benefit from barriers to entry, given the finite supply of outdoor advertising properties.

For publishers, a strong brand and high-quality content that is differentiated from competitors drive readership, which is essential for selling advertising space and content. A publisher that operates in a market with fewer media outlets can achieve and maintain a solid market position with lower investment, so the competitive environment, which can vary by region, is important.

Market Share Trajectory

Growth in a media company's share of the market relative to the growth of the overall market is another barometer of its competitive strength and future performance. Also, a company whose market share growth lags behind peers may experience difficulty attracting and retaining skilled employees, may require more promotional sales practices, and can face challenges or higher costs when raising new capital.

Business Model

The business model, which incorporates a company's level of diversity, revenue from stable or cyclical sources, and potential to benefit from or be challenged by emerging technology, is important because it influences the degree of resilience or vulnerability to secular and cyclical changes.

Media companies that we rate using this methodology have exposure to cyclical advertising demand to varying degrees, so revenue diversification and recurring revenue streams (such as carriage fees or subscriptions) can help protect a company during economic downturns. Since many broadcasters, newspapers and outdoor advertisers rely on local advertising, geographic diversification helps insulate them from regional economic cycles.

Diversification into new business opportunities, including technology or new media, is another important aspect of a company's business model, as is content differentiation. Alternatives to print, broadcast and cable television, such as online distribution, have low barriers to entry and an effectively limitless supply of advertising and content. A media company's ability to build and sustain a digital audience hinges on its ability to differentiate itself through the quality of the content it provides across all media platforms and to commercialize that content. Evaluating the digital strategy is important because these diversification efforts can increase risk and may cannibalize the existing revenue base, whereas resistance to experimentation and efforts to preserve the status quo could ultimately lead to greater erosion of cash flow.

How we assess it for the scorecard

We score this factor based on three qualitative subfactors: Market Position, Market Share Trajectory and Business Model. In the scorecard definitions, we break out two of the subfactors — Market Position and Business Model — by media segment.

Market Position

Scoring for this subfactor involves analytical judgment of the overall market position of a media company. Quantitative indicators may be useful when available but can be inconsistent, given the range of media subsectors, the variations in how companies disclose market information and, in many cases, a lack of definitive indicators to quantify market position. Therefore, we generally look at an assortment of quantitative and qualitative data for the company and its key peers in our scoring for this subfactor.

- **Broadcasters**: In this subfactor, we assess both the broadcaster's share of the market and the size of the market, We typically estimate the percentage of revenue from stations in which a broadcaster has lead rankings. For example, a radio company with a No.1 or No. 2 share of listeners in 17 of its 20 markets would score highly for this subfactor. For broadcasters in the US, the scoring for this subfactor also typically considers how many of a company's total stations are in top designated market areas (or DMAs, which are based on an estimate of the number of television households) or metropolitan survey areas (or MSAs, based on population statistics). However, top broadcasters in lower-ranked markets can maintain stronger competitive positions than weakly positioned broadcasters in larger markets. For broadcasters outside of the US, we typically gauge the attractiveness of a company's markets using population statistics, per capita gross domestic product, audience share, market structure or other metrics.
- **Cable networks, outdoor advertisers and other**: For cable networks, outdoor advertisers and other media companies, we may estimate market share and evaluate the strength of a company's competitive position based on information in financial statements. We may also consider information about audience share, total viewership and fee per subscriber for cable networks provided by third-party sources.
- **Publishers**: We focus on a publisher's ability to distinguish itself from its competitors in terms of its products, services, delivery and overall value to customers. A company with highly commoditized products or services with limited content differentiation, such as some directory publishers or commercial printers, will generally have weaker scores for this subfactor. For newspaper and magazine companies, we typically consider total online and print readership. For other publishing companies, we generally assess metrics such as books sold or pieces mailed. We also consider barriers to entry.

Market Share Trajectory

We typically score this subfactor based on our expectations for future market share performance in light of current results and recent trends. We generally estimate a company's performance relative to the subsector in which it operates to gauge whether its competitive position is improving or deteriorating. For example, we may compare a radio broadcaster's expected revenue growth to growth expectations for the overall radio market. For newspapers and magazines, we typically review company and industry trends in circulation and single-copy sales as well as trends in advertising. We typically use information found in company reports as well as industry statistics and other external sources of information in forming our estimates.

If a company operates in multiple subsectors, we generally assess market share trajectory using a weighted average approach, based on the revenue mix.

Business Model

In assessing this subfactor, we generally use a combination of quantitative indicators, estimates and analytical judgment to arrive at an overall assessment of a company's business model.

We typically evaluate the level of diversification across geographic markets, product lines or segments. Broadcasters usually provide a breakdown of stations by city and by network affiliation. For cable networks, we typically evaluate revenue diversification or concentration based on the number of channels and revenue per channel. For publishers, we typically consider the number of distinct and separate operating businesses as well as the number of geographic regions in which the publisher operates and the relative contribution of each to total revenue.

We generally compare the amount of revenue from stable sources, such as carriage or subscription fees, to the amount of revenue from advertising to assess how stable or cyclical revenue is. We may also consider the contribution to revenue from any long-term contracts and the duration of the contracts.

For most media companies, we consider the percentage of revenue that would benefit from the development of new technologies relative to the percentage of revenue that is vulnerable to shifts in consumer behavior and increasing media fragmentation. We also typically assess the flexibility of the cost structure, which affects a company's ability to benefit from emerging business opportunities.

In evaluating the revenue contribution and potential contribution from emerging businesses, we typically gauge the risk of severe cash flow deterioration that could result from the shift to a digital platform, including the risk that traditional revenue sources will

be cannibalized. We may also incorporate other changes in the business environment that could threaten or boost cash flow, such as regulatory changes or the level of government support.

Factor: Leverage and Coverage (45% weight)

Why it matters

Leverage and debt service coverage provide insight into the level of risk a company is willing to undertake. The degree of leverage is an important indicator of a company's financial flexibility, its ability to invest in growth opportunities and its capacity to pay debt service.

How we assess it for the scorecard

We score this factor based on two quantitative subfactors: Debt/EBITDA and (EBITDA – Capex)/Interest Expense).[3]

Debt / EBITDA

We use the ratio of total debt to earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (EBITDA).

For broadcasters, the numerator is total debt and the denominator is a two-year average of EBITDA. For example, if we were calculating the ratio as of 31 December 2025, the numerator would be total debt at 31 December 2025, and the denominator would be the average of EBITDA in 2024 and 2025. If political advertising revenue contributes very little to total revenue, we may also consider scenarios with annual EBITDA or EBITDA on a last-12-month basis, instead of a two-year average.

(EBITDA – Capex) / Interest Expense

We use the ratio of earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (EBITDA) minus capital expenditures (capex) to interest expense.

For broadcasters, the numerator is two-year average EBITDA minus capital expenditures and the denominator is interest expense. For example, if we were calculating the ratio as of 31 December 2025, the numerator would be the average of EBITDA minus capital expenditures in 2024 and 2025, and the denominator would be interest expense for the 12 months ending 31 December 2025. If political advertising revenue contributes very little to total revenue, we may also look at scenarios with annual EBITDA minus capital expenditures or EBITDA minus capital expenditures on a last-12-month basis, instead of a two-year average.

Factor: Financial Policy (10% weight)

Why it matters

Financial policy is an important rating determinant because it directly affects a company's debt levels, its strategic direction, the risk of adverse changes in financing and capital structure, and its overall credit quality. Financial policy encompasses the tolerance of management and the board for financial risk and their level of commitment to maintaining a strong credit profile.

Financial risk tolerance serves as a guidepost for investment and capital allocation. Liquidity management is an important aspect of financial policy and can provide insight into risk tolerance. Liquidity management is distinct from the level of liquidity, which we discuss in the "Other considerations" section.

Many companies in this sector have acquired other companies within and across media subsectors to consolidate their market positions, expand into new businesses or benefit from cost synergies. Given the limited growth opportunities in many traditional media subsectors, some companies face pressure to return cash to shareholders or develop new, faster-growth revenue streams. The quickening pace of technological change and the proliferation of competitors in online subcategories could result in further M&A as companies seek to build scale, defend market share, acquire technical expertise, increase their subscriber base or diversify their revenue.

How we assess it for the scorecard

We assess qualitatively a company's targeted credit profile or desired capital structure, and its ability to achieve its targets. We also consider a company's complexity and transparency, its track record of risk and liquidity management, and its public commitments and history of adhering to its commitments in these areas. We also consider management's operating performance and use of cash flow through different phases of economic and industry cycles, as well as how management responds to key events, such as changes in the credit markets and liquidity environment, legal actions, competitive challenges and regulatory pressures.

When considering event risks in the context of scoring financial policy, we assess the likelihood and potential effect of M&A or other types of balance-sheet-transforming events. We assess management's appetite for M&A activity, with a focus on the type of transactions (i.e., core competency or new business) and funding decisions. We also evaluate the frequency and materiality of acquisitions and previous financing choices. A history of debt-financed or credit-transforming acquisitions generally results in a lower score for this factor. We may also consider a company's willingness to sell itself and the negative repercussions that could result, such as through a leveraged buyout transaction.

We also consider a company's and its owners' past record of balancing shareholder returns and debtholders' interests. We are likely to take a negative view in scoring this factor when a company has a track record of favoring shareholder returns at the expense of debtholders.

Other considerations

Ratings may reflect other considerations that are not in the scorecard, usually because the credit importance of these considerations varies widely among companies in this sector or because they may be important only under certain circumstances or for a subset of companies. Such considerations can include financial controls and the quality of financial reporting; corporate legal structure; the quality and experience of management; assessments of corporate governance, as well as environmental and social considerations; exposure to uncertain licensing regimes; and possible government interference in some countries. Regulatory, litigation, liquidity, technology and reputational risk, as well as changes to consumer and business spending patterns, competitor strategies and macroeconomic trends can also be considerations that affect ratings.

The following are examples of other considerations that may be reflected in our ratings and may cause ratings to be different from scorecard-indicated outcomes.

Environmental, social and governance considerations

Where environmental, social and governance (ESG) issues are meaningful for credit profiles, we incorporate them into our ratings analysis in a variety of ways in the application of our sector-specific methodologies. As one part of our overall credit analysis, we consider how ESG considerations could affect the qualitative and quantitative factors and subfactors in the scorecard.

Even where ESG considerations do not affect the measures in the scorecard, or where they cannot be quantified, we incorporate them into our overall analysis of credit drivers that are meaningful to the rating. As a result, we may incorporate these ESG risks qualitatively outside of the scorecard. As part of our ratings analysis, we may establish Issuer Profile Scores (IPSs), which indicate our opinion of the extent to which a given company is exposed to E, S and G risks (incorporating ESG-specific mitigants) or benefits from its exposure to E, S or G. The IPSs are inputs to credit ratings. For more information, see our methodology that describes our general principles for assessing ESG risks.[4]

Liquidity

Liquidity is an important rating consideration for all companies, and extremely weak liquidity can heavily affect ratings in many cases. Our liquidity assessment can be particularly important where there are significant short-term demands on a company's liquidity, for example, in highly seasonal operating environments where working capital needs must be considered. We form an opinion on likely short-term liquidity requirements from the perspective of both sources and uses of cash. For more information, see our liquidity cross-sector methodology.[5]

Regulatory considerations

Companies in this sector are subject to varying degrees of regulatory oversight. Effects of these regulations may entail limitations on operations, higher costs, and higher potential for technology disruptions and demand substitution. Regional differences in regulation, implementation or enforcement may advantage or disadvantage a particular company.

Our view of future regulatory requirements is important because it is the basis for our expectations of future financial metrics and of a company's ability to generate sufficient cash flow relative to its debt burden over the medium and longer term.

Management strategy

The quality of management is an important factor supporting a company's credit strength. Assessing the execution of business plans over time can be helpful in assessing management's business strategies, policies and philosophies, and in evaluating management

performance relative to that of competitors and our projections. Management's track record of adhering to stated plans, commitments and guidelines provides insight into management's likely future performance, including in stressed situations.

Financial controls

We rely on the accuracy of audited financial statements to assign and monitor ratings in this sector. The quality of financial statements may be influenced by internal controls, including the proper tone at the top, centralized operations, and consistency in accounting policies and procedures. Auditors' reports on the effectiveness of internal controls, auditors' comments in financial reports and unusual restatements of financial statements or delays in regulatory filings may indicate weaknesses in internal controls.

Excess cash balances

Some companies in this sector may maintain cash balances (meaning liquid short-term investments, as well as cash) that far exceed their operating needs. This excess cash can be an important credit consideration.

The amount of cash required to run a business can vary materially based on the regions of operation and the specific subsectors in which a company operates. As a result, we typically assess cash on the balance sheet qualitatively, taking into account a company's track record and its financial and liquidity policies. Cash holdings may be a material mitigant in our scenario analyses of potential acquisitions, share buybacks or special dividends. We assess possible uses of cash, especially for companies that may be acquisitive or under pressure to return cash to shareholders. By contrast, some companies maintain large cash holdings for long periods in excess of their operating and liquidity needs solely because of conservative financial policies, which provides a stronger indication of an enduring approach that will benefit creditors. Large cash holdings provide some buffers against credit deterioration, and we typically consider cash balances in our analysis of near-term liquidity sources and uses. See the "Liquidity" section for more information.

In accordance with our view of how a company will use its cash, we may use total debt or net debt in our forward-looking view of credit metrics for the Leverage and Coverage factor. We may also cite rating thresholds based on these metrics.

Additional metrics

The metrics included in the scorecard are those that are generally most important in assigning ratings to companies in this sector; however, we may use additional metrics to inform our analysis of specific companies. These additional metrics may be important in our forward-looking view of metrics in the scorecard or in other rating considerations.

For example, free cash flow is not always an important differentiator of credit profiles. Strong companies with excellent investment opportunities may demonstrate multiyear periods of negative free cash flow while retaining solid access to capital and credit, because these investments will yield stable cash flow in future years. Weaker companies with limited access to credit may have positive free cash flow for a period of time because they have curtailed the investments necessary to maintain their assets and future cash-generating prospects. However, in some cases, free cash flow can be an important driver of the future liquidity profile of a company.

Non-wholly owned subsidiaries

Some companies in this sector choose to dilute their equity stake in certain material subsidiaries, such as through an initial public offering or a sale to a private investor, which may, in some cases, negatively affect future financial flexibility. While such transactions may improve cash holdings on a one-off basis, selling minority interests in subsidiaries may have a negative effect on cash flow available to the parent company that consolidated financial statements may not fully reflect. For example, in the case of an equity stake reduction in a subsidiary down to 75%, in the parent's financial statements, the subsidiary's revenue and EBITDA would typically still be consolidated at the group level.

The presence of minority stakes can increase structural subordination and reduce the parent's share of dividend flows from a non-wholly owned subsidiary. While less frequent, the sale of a minority stake may have provisions that further limit the parent's financial flexibility, for instance restrictions on cash pooling with other members of the corporate family, limitations on dividends and distributions, or arms-length business requirements. Minority stakeholders may have seats on the board of the subsidiary.

In many cases, we consider the impact of non-wholly owned subsidiaries qualitatively. For example, we may find that an additional view of financial results, such as analyzing cash flow on a proportional consolidation basis, may be useful to inform our analysis. When equity dilution or structural subordination from non-wholly owned subsidiaries is material and negative, the credit impact is captured in our ratings.

For companies that hold material minority interest stakes (investor companies), consolidated funds from operations typically includes the dividends received from the equity-accounted entity, while none of its debt is consolidated. The investor company's cash flow may be subject to interruption if it is required for the equity-accounted entity's debt service, capital expenditures or other cash needs. The debt of the equity-accounted entity is structurally senior to the investor company's debt. When an equity-accounted entity has a material level of debt, we may estimate one or more of the investor company's financial metrics using proportional consolidation or another approach to inform our analysis of consolidated financials and capture the credit impact of these considerations in our ratings.

Event risk

We also recognize the possibility that an unexpected event could cause a sudden and sharp decline in a company's fundamental creditworthiness, which may cause the assigned rating to be lower than the scorecard-indicated outcome. Event risks — which vary and can range from leveraged recapitalizations to sudden regulatory changes or liabilities from an accident — can overwhelm even a stable, well-capitalized company. Other types of event risks may include M&A, asset sales, spinoffs, shareholder distributions, litigation, natural disasters, pandemics, significant cybercrime events and geopolitical conflicts.

Parental support

Ownership can provide ratings lift for a particular company if it is owned by a highly rated owner or owners who view it to be of strategic importance. In our analysis of parental support, we consider whether the parent has the financial capacity and strategic incentives to provide support to the company in times of stress or financial need (e.g., a major capital investment or advantaged operating agreement), or if it has done so in the past. Conversely, if the parent puts a high dividend burden on the company, which in turn reduces its flexibility, the ratings will reflect this risk. For more information, see our cross-sector methodology on assessing the impact of financial support from a parent, subsidiary or affiliate in the absence of a guarantee.[6]

Government-related issuers may receive ratings uplift from expected government support. However, for certain companies, government ownership can have a negative effect on the underlying Baseline Credit Assessment (BCA). For example, price controls, onerous taxation and high distributions can have a negative effect on a company's underlying credit profile. For more information on the BCA, see *Rating Symbols and Definitions* and our cross-sector methodology for government-related issuers.[7]

Other institutional support

In some countries, large companies have received government or banking support in the event of financial difficulties because of their overall importance to the functioning of the economy. We consider whether group and banking relationships may provide support when systemically important companies encounter significant financial stress.

As a notable example, some of our corporate ratings in Japan incorporate the government or banking support we expect to be provided, based on historical experience, to large and systemically important companies. Over the years, this support has resulted in lower levels of default for Japanese companies than might otherwise have occurred.

Scorecard-indicated outcome

We arrive at a scorecard-indicated outcome by first mapping the outcome for each factor or subfactor to a numeric score, and then by producing an aggregate numeric score and the equivalent alphanumeric outcome.

Mapping scorecard factors to a numeric score

We map the outcome of each factor or subfactor in the scorecard to a broad Moody's rating category and to a corresponding numeric score. We score qualitative factors and subfactors based on the description by broad rating category in the scorecard. The following exhibit shows the numeric score that corresponds to each broad rating category.

Exhibit 3

Numeric scores for qualitative factors and subfactors

Aaa	Aa	A	Baa	Ba	B	Caa	Ca
1	3	6	9	12	15	18	20

Source: Moody's Ratings

We score quantitative factors and subfactors on a linear continuum. For each metric, the scorecard shows the range by broad rating category. We use the scale in the following exhibit and linear interpolation to convert the metric, based on its placement within the scorecard range, into a numeric score, which may be a fraction. As an illustrative example, if the Baa range for the ratio of revenue to interest is 50x to 100x, the numeric score for a company with a ratio of 99x – relatively strong within this range – would be closer to 7.5, while the numeric score for a company with a ratio of 51x – relatively weak within this range – would be closer to 10.5. In the scorecard footnotes, we define the endpoints of the line (i.e., the metric values that equate to the highest possible numeric score and the lowest possible numeric score).

Exhibit 4

Ranges of numeric scores for quantitative factors and subfactors

Aaa	Aa	A	Baa	Ba	B	Caa	Ca
0.5 - 1.5	1.5 - 4.5	4.5 - 7.5	7.5 - 10.5	10.5 - 13.5	13.5 - 16.5	16.5 - 19.5	19.5 - 20.5

Source: Moody's Ratings

Determining the overall scorecard-indicated outcome

We multiply the numeric score for each subfactor (or each factor, when the factor has no subfactors) by the weight of that subfactor (or factor) and sum the results to produce an aggregate numeric score. We map the aggregate numeric score back to a scorecard-indicated outcome using the ranges in the following exhibit.

Exhibit 5
Scorecard-indicated outcome

Aggregate numeric score	Scorecard-indicated outcome
x ≤ 1.5	Aaa
1.5 < x ≤ 2.5	Aa1
2.5 < x ≤ 3.5	Aa2
3.5 < x ≤ 4.5	Aa3
4.5 < x ≤ 5.5	A1
5.5 < x ≤ 6.5	A2
6.5 < x ≤ 7.5	A3
7.5 < x ≤ 8.5	Baa1
8.5 < x ≤ 9.5	Baa2
9.5 < x ≤ 10.5	Baa3
10.5 < x ≤ 11.5	Ba1
11.5 < x ≤ 12.5	Ba2
12.5 < x ≤ 13.5	Ba3
13.5 < x ≤ 14.5	B1
14.5 < x ≤ 15.5	B2
15.5 < x ≤ 16.5	B3
16.5 < x ≤ 17.5	Caa1
17.5 < x ≤ 18.5	Caa2
18.5 < x ≤ 19.5	Caa3
19.5 < x ≤ 20.5	Ca
x > 20.5	C

Source: Moody's Ratings

For example, a company with an aggregate numeric score of 11.7 would have a Ba2 scorecard-indicated outcome.

In general, the scorecard-indicated outcome is oriented to the senior unsecured rating for investment-grade companies and the corporate family rating (CFR) for speculative-grade companies. For companies that benefit from rating uplift from parental support, government ownership or other institutional support, we consider the underlying credit strength or BCA for comparison to the scorecard-indicated outcome. For more information on the BCA, see *Rating Symbols and Definitions* and our cross-sector methodology for government-related issuers.[8]

Assigning issuer-level and instrument-level ratings

After considering the scorecard-indicated outcome, other considerations and relevant cross-sector methodologies, we typically assign a senior unsecured rating for investment-grade companies and a CFR for speculative-grade companies. For government-related issuers, we assign a BCA.

We may notch individual debt instrument ratings upward or downward from the senior unsecured rating or the CFR to reflect our assessment of differences in expected loss related to an instrument's seniority level and collateral. For more information, see our cross-sector methodologies on loss given default for speculative-grade nonfinancial companies, notching corporate instrument ratings based on differences in security and priority of claim, and assigning short-term ratings.[9]

Key rating assumptions

For information about key rating assumptions that apply to methodologies generally, see *Rating Symbols and Definitions*.[10]

Limitations

In the preceding sections, we have discussed the scorecard factors and other considerations that may be important in assigning ratings. In this section, we discuss limitations that pertain to the scorecard and to the overall methodology.

Limitations of the scorecard

There are various reasons why scorecard-indicated outcomes may not map closely to assigned ratings.

For example, the scorecard may not fully capture credit loss and recovery considerations, which typically become more important as a company gets closer to default. The scorecard is also limited by its upper and lower bounds, causing scorecard-indicated outcomes to be less likely to align with ratings for companies at the upper and lower ends of the rating scale.

The weights of each scorecard factor and subfactor approximate their importance for rating decisions across the sector, but the importance of a particular factor may vary substantially based on an individual company's circumstances.

Factors outside the scorecard, including those discussed in the "Other considerations" section, may be important for ratings, and their relative importance may also vary from company to company. In addition, certain broad methodological considerations described in one or more cross-sector methodologies may be relevant to ratings in this sector.[11] These considerations include how sovereign credit quality affects nonsovereign issuers, the assessment of credit support from other entities, the relative ranking of different classes of debt and hybrid securities, and the assignment of short-term ratings.

We may use the scorecard over various historical or forward-looking periods. Furthermore, in our ratings we often incorporate directional views of risks and mitigants in a qualitative way.

General limitations of the methodology

This methodology does not include an exhaustive description of all the factors we may consider in assigning ratings in this sector. Companies in this sector may face new risks or new combinations of risks, and they may develop new strategies to mitigate risk. We seek to incorporate all material credit considerations in our ratings and to take the most forward-looking perspective that visibility into these risks and mitigants permits.

Ratings reflect our expectations for a company's future performance; however, as the forward horizon lengthens, uncertainty increases and the utility of precise estimates, as scorecard inputs or in other considerations, typically diminishes. Our forward-looking opinions are based on assumptions that may prove, in hindsight, to have been incorrect. Reasons for this could include unanticipated changes in any of the following: the macroeconomic environment, general financial market conditions, industry competition, disruptive technology, or regulatory and legal actions. In any case, predicting the future is subject to substantial uncertainty.

Moody's related publications

Credit ratings are primarily determined through the application of sector methodologies. Certain broad methodological considerations (described in one or more cross-sector methodologies) may also be relevant to the determination of credit ratings of issuers and instruments. A list of sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found here.

Data summarizing the historical robustness and predictive power of credit ratings can be found here.

For more information, see *Rating Symbols and Definitions*, which is available here.

Endnotes

1 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

2 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

3 For definitions of our most common metrics, see our cross-sector methodology that describes our financial statement adjustments for nonfinancial corporations. A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

4 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

5 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

6 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

7 Links to *Rating Symbols and Definitions* and to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

8 Links to *Rating Symbols and Definitions* and to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

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10 A link to *Rating Symbols and Definitions* can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

11 A link to a list of our sector and cross-sector methodologies can be found in the "Moody's related publications" section.

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